UNITED STATES OF AMERICA
FEDERAL ENERGY REGULATORY COMMISSION

Interconnection of Large Loads to The Interstate Transmission System	))	Docket No. RM26-4-000

REPLY COMMENTS OF
AMERICANS FOR A CLEAN ENERGY GRID
(December 5, 2025)

Initial comments in this docket reinforced what the Commission already knows: rapid interconnection of new resources needs new transmission. Interconnecting both load and generation – to constrained transmission system will not be effective unless significant new grid infrastructure is built, and those new resources must be incorporated into forward-looking planning. Pursuant to the Federal Energy Regulatory Commission's ("FERC" or "Commission") Notice Inviting Comments[1] and subsequent Notice Granting Extension of Time to submit comments[2] in the above-captioned docket regarding the proposed Advance Notice of Proposed Rulemaking ("ANOPR") that the U.S. Department of Energy released on October 23, 2025, pursuant to section 403 of the Department of Energy Organization Act,[3] Americans for a Clean Energy Grid ("ACEG") is pleased to submit these reply comments. ACEG is a non-profit group representing a diverse coalition of stakeholders—including utilities, hyper-scalers, independent transmission and generation developers, and non-profit groups—all focused on the need to expand, integrate, and modernize the high-capacity grid in the United States.[4]

Fundamentally, when managed correctly, interconnecting large loads to the grid is a win-win for all customers; the transmission system that serves everyone benefits from additional investment: new costs can be shared among a larger customer base in ways that will mitigate,

[1] *Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate Transmission System*, Notice Inviting Comments, Docket No. RM26-4-000 (Oct. 27, 2025).
[2] *Interconnection of Large Loads to the Interstate Transmission System*, Notice Granting Extension of Time, Docket No. RM26-4-000 (Nov. 7, 2025).
[3] 42 U.S.C. § 7173.
[4] These comments do not necessarily reflect the views of individual ACEG supporters.

and in some cases reduce, costs for existing customers, and large loads gain the resilience and reliability associated with grid interconnection. Initial comments to the ANOPR proposed to accelerate the interconnection of data centers and other large loads to ensure national security and unlock economic opportunities. We strongly support deployment of infrastructure to meet these goals, and are mindful of the need to implement the proposals in the ANOPR in a way that addresses the affordability impacts on customers and ensures harmony with state and federal jurisdiction over electric facilities and services.

A review of the substantial record in this docket confirms broad agreement on these points. Commenters representing utilities, hyperscalers, public power, regional grid operators, and industrial customers have all highlighted the same fundamental reality: the grid cannot support a new era of high-density, high-demand loads without a corresponding expansion in transmission capacity.

I. The Greatest Need for Successful Large-Load Interconnection Is More Regional and Interregional Transmission

Many commenters underscored that interconnecting large loads requires significant upgrades to the existing transmission grid. These upgrades are often not local or incremental; instead, they involve broader buildout to alleviate congestion, increase transfer capability, and maintain reliability under stressed conditions. The Data Center Coalition said it well:

> The core challenge facing the electric system today is not merely procedural delay in generator interconnection studies, but the lack of sufficient transmission infrastructure and forward planning to accommodate new load and new generation in a timely manner. Generator interconnection queues have grown into multi-year bottlenecks … because the transmission system lacks sufficient unencumbered headroom to integrate these resources. In many cases, projects cannot proceed because needed network upgrades were not planned, permitted, or built in advance. The interconnection backlog is thus a symptom of a deeper and more structural issue: the grid was not expanded or modernized at the pace that changing system needs require. The lack of supply to meet today's demand is not a failure of market interest – rather a failure of infrastructure. … A planning construct designed for marginal load variation is no longer adequate when load is materializing at utility-scale magnitude and on industrial timelines.[5]

[5] Data Center Coalition Comments at 8-9.

Pointing out that several RTOs are warning of potential reliability issues, the Data Center Coalition noted that these warnings "are evidence that transmission and interconnection infrastructure has not kept pace with economic growth or system reliability needs."[6]

While much has been made of the value of co-location and curtailment flexibility – and certainly these are key tools for achieving speed to market and mitigating broader impacts of these large loads – the long-term goal of many of these customers is to be grid-connected in order to ensure the reliability and resilience that these facilities need.[7] One data center developer noted that they would pursue any model that would allow them to get up and running quickly, but that they and their "customers prefer to develop grid-connected sites to promote reliability and resilience to ensure operational continuity for its data center customers and to promote the efficient and secure operation of the grid."[8]

II. Transmission Planning Must Proactively Include Anticipated Large Loads

A consistent theme in comments is the need to bolster transmission planning is the inadequacy of the current reactive approach to load-driven upgrades. Under existing rules, transmission providers generally respond to load requests only once an interconnection application is submitted. This reactive structure has left many regions unprepared for the scale and pace of emerging demand. AEP prioritized this issue in noting that the current

> siloed approach to transmission planning … will not deliver infrastructure fast enough to ensure the United States continues to be a leader in artificial intelligence and is able to grow its manufacturing base. Widespread adoption of proactive transmission planning will better anticipate and plan for load and generation in an efficient and cost-effective manner. [9]

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[6] Id. at 9 (citing NERC and RTO reports on declining reserve margins, elevated risks of emergency actions, and reliability risks driven by transmission constraints).
[7] Comments of Shell Energy North America (US), L.P. Comments at 3,
[8] Comments of Vantage Data Centers at 2.
[9] AEP Comments at 4-5.

This requires robust forecasting at the regional level to ensure planning is accurate and timely. ClearPath echoed this need for coordinated interconnection studies of load and generators along with transmission planning in their comments:

> Proactively planning transmission can increase transparency on the cost and timing of interconnection and identify cost-effective transmission solutions. In particular, when transmission is proactively planned, the costs for interconnection are provided to interconnection customers upfront, and developers have greater clarity on when they can interconnect, reducing uncertainty and the speculative behavior that increases queue timelines.[10]

Customers viewed this as a temporal challenge – some reforms may be appropriate only in the short-run, but "regulations that are squarely focused on transmission grid transparency, load forecasting, and grid efficiency could be permanent reforms."[11] Google added there is a need

> "to plan better in order to develop a transmission grid that can support the nation's digital infrastructure needs. … Doing so requires a holistic transmission planning process that harmonizes both new load interconnection with new generation supply. … transmission planners must have a realistic picture of the generators and the large loads planning to interconnect to the transmission grid if they are to plan the grid in an efficient, cost-effective, and reliable manner."[12]

The Electricity Customer Alliance reiterated this point, noting that, "[c]apturing this opportunity requires, among other things, more holistic transmission planning to better account for these large loads and associated generation in development to serve them and identify the most economically efficient transmission expansion opportunities."[13] MISO cited their reforms as a strength in meeting the challenge: "Transmission and generation are critical enablers to facilitate the interconnections of large loads. MISO has updated and enhanced its processes across the transmission and resource planning horizons to efficiently support large load additions and improve the integration of large loads."[14]

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[10] ClearPath comments at 5, noting recent reforms by CAISO on its interconnection process and SPP in its Consolidated Planning Process.
[11] Joint Comments of the Industrial Customer Organizations at 21.
[12] Google comments at 3-4.
[13] Comments of Electricity Customer Alliance at 2.
[14] Comments of the Midcontinent Independent System Operator Inc. at 6.

III. Strong Alignment Across Commenters: Transmission Expansion Is Essential

Across the docket, numerous parties made clear that enhancing the interconnection process alone will not be enough; expanding transmission, at scale, is imperative. As the Data Center Coalition put it, interconnecting large loads "must be understood as a core transmission-infrastructure priority – one that modernizes and expands the grid at the scale required, not merely streamlines procedural steps."[15] Iron Mountain echoed this sentiment in providing that it "supports federal and state initiatives to align generation and transmission and build new resources."[16] Exelon, as well, stated, "Significant new generation, transmission, and distribution infrastructure will be required to reliably interconnect new large loads."[17] Microsoft added that it "recognizes that the expansion of data centers performing cloud computing and artificial intelligence ("AI") operations necessitates significant investment in electric transmission and generation capacity …."[18]

Customers, who will bear the cost, agree: new transmission infrastructure is critical to meeting large loads and enhancing the grid overall. The Load Flexibility Parties note that, in addition to load flexibility and other quickly deployable solutions, "new generation and transmission infrastructure will be part of the solution."[19] Where new technologies that make better use of the grid, they are essential, "[i]n addition to new transmission lines," to integrate new large loads.[20] Even the Large Public Power Council, with appropriate caveats about ensuring that customers are protected from inappropriate cost-shifting, states that it "supports expansion of the electric grid in order to enable data center growth and AI industry development."[21]

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[15] Data Center Coalition Comments at 10.
[16] Iron Mountain Data Centers at 2.
[17] Exelon comments at 3.
[18] Initial comments of Microsoft Inc. at 1.
[19] Joint Comment of the Load Flexibility Parties at 2.
[20] Comments of American Transmission Company LLC at 3.
[21] Comments of the Large Public Power Council at 2.

IV. Recommendations for Commission Action

While this docket is still in the early stages, several recommendations stand out and have broad support:

- Require improved regional forecasting for significant loads (75 MW or more).
- Ensure cost recovery and cost-allocation mechanisms that protect existing customers while allowing large loads to participate fairly in – and benefit from – the broader grid.
- Direct proactively planned multi-value high-capacity transmission as part of the solution, whether through existing mechanisms or robust Order No. 1920 compliance.

The Commission sits at a pivotal moment. The U.S. economy is undergoing a structural transformation in how and where electricity is consumed, and the transmission system must meet the moment. No procedural refinement or queue improvement can substitute for the foundational need for more regional and interregional transmission nor for planning frameworks that anticipate, rather than react to, large-load growth.

The record in this docket shows that Commission action is needed. The Commission has both the authority and the responsibility to ensure that the nation's grid is prepared for sustained economic expansion. By expediting the buildout of regional and interregional transmission planned to meet the needs of new large loads, the Commission can support reliable service and enable economic growth while ensuring that rates remain just and reasonable and customers are protected. We look forward to working with the Commission to attain these goals.

Respectfully submitted,

/s/ Christina Hayes

Christina Hayes
Executive Director
Americans for a Clean Energy Grid
10 G Street NE #440
Washington, D.C. 20002